This, however, made the king furious.

Ashoka, therefore, declared: 'If the throne is rightfully mine, let the gods crown me with the royal diadem!' And instantly the gods did so. When King Bindusara saw this, he vomited blood and passed away.[36]

Ashoka was finally consecrated in 269/268 BCE when apparently he was 'alone continuing his race'.[37] The *Ashokavadana* supports the idea that Ashoka's ascent to the Mauryan throne followed the hot and bloody contest: Susima is said to have been roasted alive when he returned to Pataliputra. It seems 'he fell into a ditch' that happened to have been filled earlier with the live coals of acacia wood. Famed for his compassion as a Buddhist, Ashoka seems to have done a fair amount over his years as an aspiring monarch to require a long life of contrition and contemplation.

But for us to stretch his Buddhist inclinations to cover the sins of his youth would need Ashoka to have expressed his own thoughts on the matter, make some sort of admission, or allude to feelings of guilt about the manner in which he assumed the throne. Is there anything in his edicts which can make us believe that the later textual accounts of his accession are based on hard self-confessional evidence? To make sense of all this, it is necessary to go back to Ashoka's reticence over his early life and lineage, to his silence about being the son and grandson of earlier Mauryan rulers. It is tempting to speculate that one reason for his silence was because he became emperor by violating the tradition of primogeniture, specially as his father had wanted his first-born son to succeed him. In such circumstances, it would have been logical for Ashoka to draw a curtain over his early life and say as little as possible about it. In fact, given what we can glean of his probable misdeeds from texts that are in fact intent on showing his beatitude, Ashoka's silence on these years of his life is deafening. Unless in the future some scintillating new discovery comes along to piece together this puzzle—of why a man so explicit and articulate about his reigning years chose to be so taciturn about his early life, it is extremely unlikely that